

LITERARY STYLES IN THE BIBLE

How to Read the Bible • BibleProject

THE BIG IDEA

The Bible is one unified story told through many literary styles. To read it well, notice how each style communicates and read with the right expectations.

43%
NARRATIVE

33%
POETRY

24%
PROSE DISCOURSE

1

NARRATIVE — STORIES SHAPE HOW WE SEE

Stories arrange events into meaningful sequences. Through characters, desire, conflict, and resolution, they explore life's great questions and give hope. Biblical characters are often deeply flawed: do not merely imitate them—see yourself in them and let their stories reshape your perspective.

2

POETRY — IMAGES AWAKEN IMAGINATION

Poetry uses dense, creative language, imagery, and metaphor to engage emotion and imagination. It breaks us out of familiar mental ruts and helps us envision the world differently. Biblical poetry includes psalms and songs, wisdom poetry, and the passionate poetry of the prophets.

3

PROSE DISCOURSE — IDEAS CALL FOR RESPONSE

Speeches, letters, laws, and essays build ideas into a logical argument. Follow the sequence: How does one thought connect to the next? What conclusion follows? Prose discourse seeks a consistent, reasoned—and often practical—response.

TAKE-HOME LINE

Genre isn't a technicality — it's the author telling you how to read.

Ask: What kind of writing is this? What should I pay attention to? What questions does this style invite me to ask?